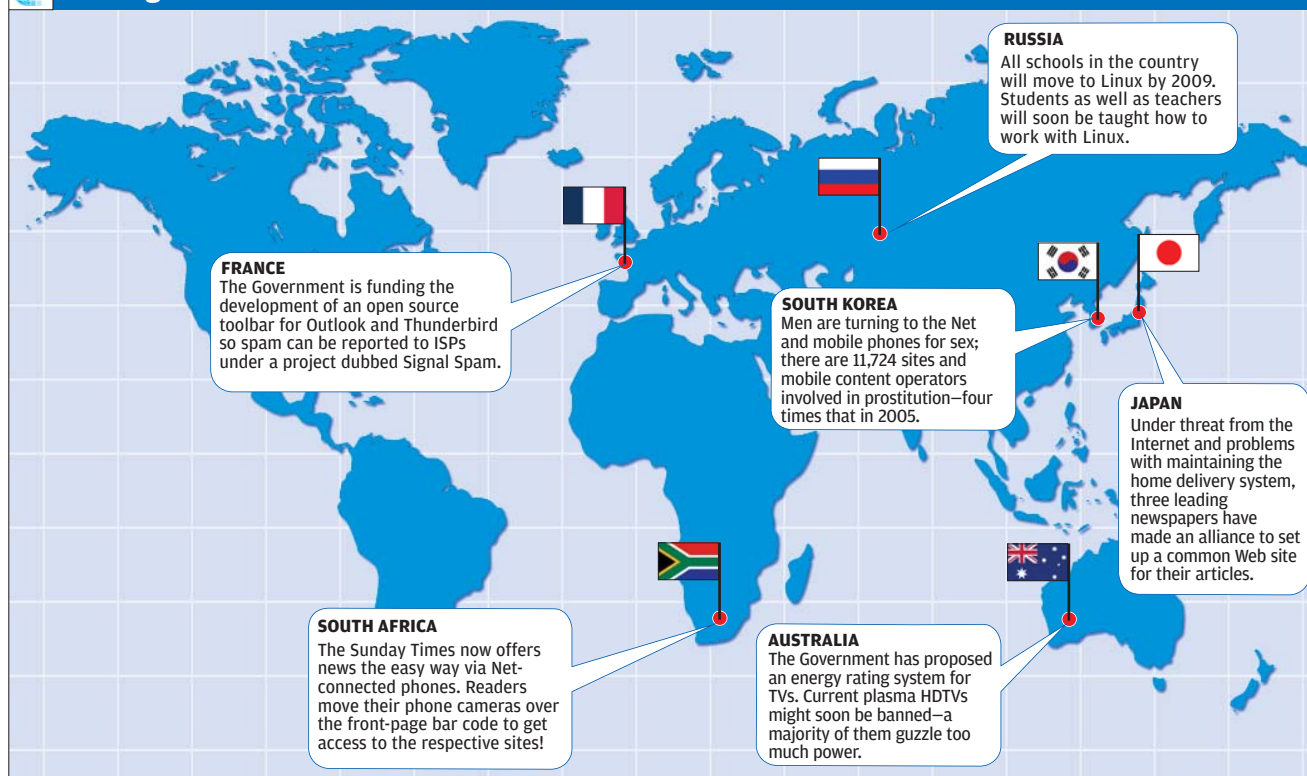




one could think up theories of all sorts—get rid of the Western Influence, perhaps, or get citizens to believe in the virtues of regimented hard work. In any case, half-baked laws like this one can only lead to what any old ban means—Work Around. But do not forget that the Chinese government, while progressive, still wields power of the sort that can say, “No more games.” Or perhaps “No more American games.”

WE SAW THIS COMING

Health Records Go Online...?

Imagine a family doctor looking up your medical history online after you’ve gone to him or her with a complaint. On the face of it, it seems a good idea: everything is categorised, your doctor needn’t ask you for too much extra information, and so on. HealthVault, a

Web service Microsoft is now offering, stores your medical records online. For once, this comes before—something we’re now anticipating—“Google Health.”

The site incorporates a health-specific search engine and lets you save your searches. The money will come in to Microsoft through health-related ads on the search pages, but those won’t be targeted ads—for now. Access to the site will require a Windows Live ID and password, which you can, of course, share with healthcare providers.

Now the system just allows you to enter personal details along with medical statistics like blood pressure, blood glucose levels, and so on. So what happens if you enter something incorrect? There’s no way a doctor can add medical details to your profile, so it’s hardly a formal programme—the information is unverifiable by a medical expert. As a matter of fact, the site proclaims, “HealthVault was built on the principle that you should control your own health records.” Unless we’re

missing something really obvious here, we thought doctors should tell us what we’re suffering from.

In 2001, EPIC (the Electronic Privacy Information Center) filed complaints alleging that the Microsoft Passport system facilitates online profiling. EPIC claimed Microsoft officials had stated that the goal of the system was to create a profile of every Internet user, to “up-sell” individuals to subscription accounts, and to use targeted advertising.

Some are alarmed: they can see a problem with too much information getting online. It’s all usernames and passwords as of now; people tend to reuse passwords—and then there’s the idea, pretty much Passport-like, that you should have a single sign-in for all your services. Perhaps we’ll have something beyond passwords when we get to “single sign-on to the Web,” but that’s another story.

“Whether you need to search the Web for the most up-to-date treatments, catalog existing health

records, receive test results, or monitor current physical readings, HealthVault gives you the control you need,” goes the verbal jingle. Search the Web? It’s been reported that too many searches bring up porn results, even searches for which Google’s general search engine brings up fewer porn results. Catalogue health records? Why, we do have paper and files. Receive test results... how about posting or e-mailing them over?

It just seems a push to go online, online, online—with little justification or even attraction. Along the lines of EPIC, we don’t see much but targeted advertising here.

CATCH-UP

Yahoo!—More Google Than Ever!

Various search engine comparisons and polls have been done by people or bodies with